

THE BEST

The cost of freedom on the road: Bike: \$500 Rego: nil

This week *Good Weekend* starts a new column, *The Best*. It's a guide to the best of everything you can buy and enjoy.

By KEITH DUNSTAN

THE TRUTH is I don't entirely loathe automobiles. But when the ultimate crunch comes and we are all forced to return to public transport, could I suggest a number of uses for your family vehicle:

- Seal all the doors and windows, fill it with water and turn it into a charming aquarium;
- Take out the seats, fit it with shelves and turn it into a hand linen cupboard;
- Put it in the garden, fit it with a telephone and a hi-fi and never again be worried by rowdy teenagers;
- Cut the top off evenly and smoothly, fill it with earth and you have an enchanting flower bed to brighten your patio. Also ideal for cumquats, roses and camellias.

Oh, automobiles do have their uses. They are good for carting firewood, collecting aunty from the station, carrying rubbish to the tip and coping with 15 suitcases when you go on holidays. Yet, as you will have noticed from recent petrol increases, apart from whisky and beer, they are the most clever taxation device ever devised by government.

It would be cheaper to keep a child at a religion-blessed boarding school or run a mistress.

Now it baffles me why more people do not switch to bicycles. I have been commuting to work by bicycle for 25 years. No fuel problems, no parking problems, no dieting problems and one gains an utterly marvellous relationship with the dry cleaner.

But bicyclists are a persecuted minority in Australia. You will notice

that there are signs on all the freeways "No animals, dogs, pedestrians, cyclists." It is almost as if they forgot to add "and other pests."

I became a born-again cyclist during one of Melbourne's countless transport strikes, no trams, buses or trains. I borrowed a bicycle and rode the 12-odd kilometres to the city. To my surprise I got to the office more quickly and efficiently than by train, tram, bus or car. I never got over it.

It wasn't so much the saving in time. What had been a dreadful bore before, now was the best time of the day. One could look at the changing of the seasons along the Yarra, observe the birds, smell what everyone was having for breakfast or dinner.

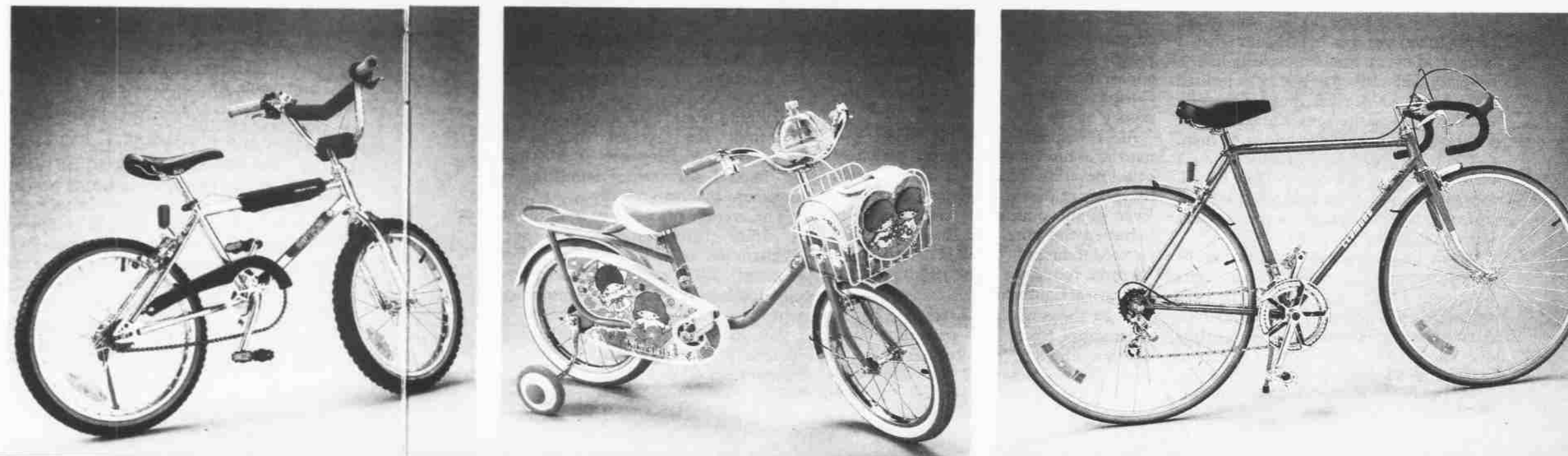
But you can imagine what it was like at the office. Giving up automobiles is very unhealthy. It arouses suspicion, like not wearing a tie or saying you love John Halfpenny.

Some people even took me aside and said that if I was really down on my luck they could assist with a small loan that would help to buy a Mini-Minor.

If you are forced into a minority group you become progressively more strange. Bicyclists, if they are going to survive, must look vulgar. Bright orange is a

Above right: the Repco Sierra. Right: the 20-inch Crossrider BMX Freewheel for children who want to go hard on their bikes. It can be ridden from age eight years to 15 years. Price: \$239. Right, centre: the 16-inch girls' Clamont Kiki and Lala is equipped with a back pedal brake as well as front hand brakes for extra safety. The brake lever is adjustable. Price: \$219, suits ages three to seven. Far right: the Clamont Six Twelve is available for both men and women. A key feature is the bike's click position gear selector. Price: \$359

Bicycles at right from Sydney's Clarence St Cyclery



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